
A GOP Lawmaker Compromised His Ideals to Suck Up to Donald Trump. You'll Absolutely Guess What Happened Next.

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Five years ago, and to his enduring credit, Louisiana Sen. Bill Cassidy voted to convict Donald Trump on an impeachment charge of “incitement of insurrection.” In a brief statement afterward, Cassidy said, “I voted to convict Trump because he is guilty.”

Cassidy, representing a deep-red state and at the time still ascending toward a committee chairmanship and a meaningful tenure in the Senate, had the most to lose politically of the seven Republicans who voted to convict Trump. He had, however, just won reelection in 2020. He may have bet that Trump would simply disappear into the shadows of American political life before Cassidy had to stand before voters again.

As we are all more aware with each passing minute, that bet was wrong. And lest anyone think that Trump might forgive something like an impeachment vote against him, he quashed that over the weekend when he [prospectively endorsed](#) GOP Rep. Julia Letlow in a primary against Cassidy, urging, “RUN, JULIA, RUN!!!,” on his social media account.

Letlow announced her candidacy Tuesday morning. The key lines of her [launch video](#), which features a great many photos of Trump, or of herself with Trump: “A state as conservative as ours? We shouldn’t have to wonder how our senator will vote when the pressure is on.”

Cassidy, in a statement Tuesday, said that Letlow had called him before her announcement and “said she respected me and that I had done a good job.”

He added, “I will continue to do a good job when I win re-election.”

His confidence may not be well placed. Cassidy, who entered the Senate in 2015, was [censured by his party](#) following his Trump conviction vote. A Trump endorsement in a GOP primary, in a very red state, means the world, and Letlow is not a gadfly candidate. If Cassidy still wants to have a meaningful tenure in the Senate, he should treat this year as his last. Because there’s a great chance it is.

The senator, who also failed to endorse Trump in 2024, has since done everything he can to win the president’s favor—or at least his indifference. That included absorbing oceans of criticism for his role in supporting one of Trump’s key nominees with whom Cassidy was plainly uncomfortable. Trump must have enjoyed watching him twist in the wind this way for the past year just as much as he enjoys turning on those just as they get their hopes up that he won’t. It’s another warning to anyone who ever might think they’re safe from a change in Trump’s mood.

Those familiar with his campaign-rally routines will know [Trump’s many recitations](#) of “The Snake,” something he refers to as a poem but is really a song from the 1960s. The lyrics are about a woman who takes a snake into her home and is then bit by it, to which the snake says, “You knew damn well I was a snake before you took me in.” Trump has long used this as a metaphor against lax immigration policies, while everyone else observes that it’s a form of projection and a warning to those who put their trust in Trump.

Cassidy seemed to believe that he could get over the hurdle with Trump in the first year of Trump's second presidency and at least win his neutrality in a GOP Senate primary. Most notably, Cassidy, despite being a physician who was visibly disgusted with vaccine conspiracy theorist Robert F. Kennedy Jr.'s nomination to head the Department of Health and Human Services, [cast the key vote](#) to confirm Kennedy in the Senate Finance Committee last year. Cassidy did so after receiving a variety of "assurances" from Kennedy that he wouldn't make all sorts of ruptures to mainstream public health, which Kennedy has gone on to do anyway.

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And while Cassidy has been more and more critical of Kennedy over the past year—to no apparent avail—he's otherwise moved in lockstep with Trump. The pinned posts on both [his official](#) and [personal X accounts](#) show him beside the president in the Oval Office as Trump signs a MAGA hat for him. You will not see him entertaining defecting Trump on any floor votes or criticizing episodes of executive imperialism. Even for the one issue on which he has spent some capital—criticizing Kennedy—he does it by trying to drive a wedge between Kennedy and Trump. [He noted](#) in a September hearing with Kennedy, for instance, that Kennedy has been sharply critical of COVID vaccines, whereas Trump should win the Nobel Peace Prize for his role in their development.

On a surface level, Cassidy's sucking up appeared to be paying dividends. Months came and went without Trump endorsing an opponent. Politico asserted, first in an [article in September](#), that things were "looking up" for Cassidy and again, just last week, that Trump [was not expected](#) to make an endorsement in either the Louisiana or Texas GOP Senate primaries.

This may have all been a ruse to get through the peak governing season in Trump's first two years, as the president needed Cassidy as an ally on major nominations and legislation. The New York Times [reported over the weekend](#) that Trump first met with Letlow last March and told her that she would have his support if she challenged Cassidy. "But," the Times added, "he said he would have to lie low for the time being to avoid a repeat of Mr. Trump's clashes with former Senator Mitt Romney of Utah, who routinely broke with the president, including on his vote to remove him from office."

Cassidy gave the suck-up routine the old college try, but ultimately, the snake did its snake thing. Cassidy now has the choice to either try to out-Trump the Trump-endorsed candidate in the race or accept Trump's rationale in endorsing Letlow—now that he doesn't need Cassidy's help in Congress anymore—and stop offering it.

Cassidy ought to take a look at [North Carolina's Thom Tillis](#), one of his fellow GOP senators from the 2015 freshman class, and note how much more enlivened and central to the discussion he is now that he's unshackled from electoral considerations. The country is in a dangerous place right now. The Senate could use another adult voice.

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